

Question

Tell me about a time you had a conflict or disagreement at work. How did you handle it?

Answer

I think of disagreements a bit like bugs: by the time they've escalated into something big, you've usually been ignoring deeper problems. So I stay sensitive to those deeper issues and try to resolve things before they become conflicts. My approach is to assume we're on the same team with the same goals, so if we disagree it's usually about information or perspective, not intent. When that happens, I start by listening: what problem are they trying to solve, what do they know that I don't, what are they worried about? Then I explain my perspective in terms of their concerns—for example, why I think a particular approach is better for performance, maintenance, or user experience. Most disagreements I've had have dissolved at that stage because we realise we're optimising for the same thing with different mental models.

When a disagreement remains after that, I fall back on ownership and expertise. If a team lead owns the project, I'll give them all the information I have and then support their decision, even if I would have chosen differently—they carry the responsibility. If it's an area where I have more experience, like a front-end architecture decision, I'm comfortable taking the lead while staying open to feedback. That approach has kept discussions focused on the work rather than on winning arguments, and it's helped me build a reputation as someone who can navigate disagreements productively and keep teams aligned. That's the kind of thinking I'd bring: stay sensitive to friction early, resolve it before it's expensive, and keep everyone focused on the best outcome rather than who wins the argument.

Concepts to memorise

1. Core philosophy: disagreements are like bugs
 - By the time they've escalated into big conflicts, you've usually been ignoring deeper problems.
 - You stay sensitive to deeper issues and resolve things before they become conflicts.
2. First step – listen and align
 - Assume same team, same goals; disagreements are usually about information or perspective, not intent.
 - Start by listening: what problem they're solving, what they know that you don't, what they're worried about.
 - Then explain your perspective in terms of their concerns (performance, maintenance, UX, etc.).
 - Most disagreements dissolve when both sides understand each other's reasoning.

3. If disagreement remains – ownership and expertise

- If a lead owns the project, provide all information and then support their decision—they carry responsibility.
- If it's your area of expertise (e.g., front-end architecture), you're comfortable taking the lead while staying open to feedback.

4. Outcome and value to teams

- This keeps discussions focused on finding the best solution, not on winning arguments.
- Built a reputation for navigating disagreements productively and keeping teams aligned.
- What you'd bring: stay sensitive to friction early, resolve it before it's expensive, keep everyone focused on the best outcome.